

Preventing Heat Stress in Chickens

Depending on where you live, you may not need to employ more than one or two ways to help keep your chickens stay cool. However, in certain hotter parts of the country, you'll want to make sure you do a few extra things to help keep your chickens safe. Here are some practical ways to help prevent heat stress in chickens:

Provide Refreshing Water

Water is our best friend when it comes to cooling down. Serve it freely and plentifully to your flock so they can drink as much as they need. Chickens are great self-regulators and will eat and drink as much as they need. Remember to place feed and water in a shaded, cool area. For extra comfort, add some ice to cool their water. However, don't go too heavy on the ice because icy cold water can be a shock to a body that is very hot.

Supplement Electrolytes

During times of intense heat, it can be helpful to provide supplemental electrolytes in your chickens' diet. Electrolytes are essential to help your flock regulate their body processes, maintain proper hydration, and preserve their pH balance. They're especially important during the hot summer months because despite the fact that chickens don't lose fluid through sweating, their electrolyte balance can still become disrupted during hot weather. Heat stress can lead to an increase in panting. Panting can lead to the body's pH levels being disrupted, which in turn disrupts the natural electrolyte balance in a chicken's body. Supplemental electrolytes can help restore a proper electrolyte and pH balance. Our [Vitamins + Electrolytes](#) water supplement is formulated for chickens of all ages, from chicks to full-grown adult birds, and contains the essential electrolyte minerals and salts to help support your flock's health all summer long.

Avoid Overcrowding

Overcrowding means that a chicken's natural body heat (104°F) is multiplied by all its flockmates body temperatures as well. That's a lot of unwanted heat generated that can lead to heat stress, increased pecking, and even cannibalism. Overcrowding is dangerous to flock health no matter what the weather is like! The good news is it's completely avoidable. Simply provide enough space for your chickens to retreat from each other and the heat. Having a large, airy enclosure helps prevent overcrowding as does free ranging your flock during the summer. If your chickens do have to stay penned up during the summer, allow at least 8 square feet of enclosure space per chicken.

Use Fans & Increase Coop Ventilation

Natural airflow can help keep the ambient temperatures lower in the coop. Make sure there is plenty of air flow and [ventilation in the coop](#). Prop doors and windows open. If you have doors on the next boxes, you may even want to prop those open too. While ventilation is very important, you also need to keep predator safety in mind. You might need to use a metal grate to block the windows or doors, if you didn't have one built in already. At a minimum, make sure that your coop has enough ventilation to allow the hot air to escape and bring in any breezes.

If you're able to run electricity to your yard, you can set up a fan for the chickens in their enclosure or the coop. A fan will be your flock's favorite addition to the coop, allowing them to get a precious breeze under their fluffy down. They'll love it even more if you place frozen gallon jugs of water in front of it to really blow cool air around.

Make Frozen Treats & Encourage Hydration

Sipping ice water cools us from the inside out and helps regulate our body temperature. The same principle applies to your flock. Providing cool water can reduce stress on your flock and help them regulate their internal body temperature.

One of the easiest tricks to get your chickens to hydrate on a hot day is to sprinkle protein-rich snacks like [Grubblies](#) into cold water. While they bob for their snacks and get extra protein, they'll gobble up plenty of water along the way. You can also chop up veggies and fruit scraps, add a few Grubblies, and make little ice cube snacks to add to your flock's water and encourage drinking.

Provide your chickens with healthy, refreshing snacks along with their cool water. You can try freezing their feed or freezing fruits like watermelon, grapes, apples, cucumbers, salad greens, tomatoes, and other veggie scraps.

Provide Shade

Summer shade is crucial, blocking blocks solar radiation and harmful UV rays. The ground beneath a tree makes for cooler dust baths too, making it easier to regulate body temperature and avoid heat stress. Make sure that you provide ample shade for your chickens in their favorite hangout areas. If they don't have natural shade, you can hang a shade cloth over their coop, run, or wherever they prefer to hang out. You can use a gardening shade cloth, tarp, old curtains or sheets, or even plant some trees to provide shade. Try to include both natural and manmade shades sources in your flock's yard or enclosure. When rigging up a shade source, ensure that it does not use a black or dark material, which will actually absorb heat and contribute hot air to the surroundings.

Hose Down the Coop and Surrounding Areas

Cold water helps cool things down by absorbing some of the heat itself. Hose down the coop roof and wet the perimeter of the coop and enclosure to make those areas cooler and more refreshing for your flock. This will aid in lowering the overall ambient temperature of the surrounding area.

Also, wet the ground in any areas they like to hang out during the day. On a particularly hot day when temperatures are well over 90°F to 100°F, water things down as often as you can. Don't forget to water their favorite dust-bathing areas. Chickens not only dust bathe to keep their skin and feathers clean, they also do it to help regulate their body temperatures. By providing them with dampened and cooled dirt to dust bathe in, they can keep themselves cool when they kick the wet dirt onto their skin.

Provide your chickens with extra sources of drinking water, including tubs they can step in to keep cool as needed.

Set Up Misters

If the eggstra shade and hosed down coop aren't doing the trick, particularly if you live in areas where summers can get really hot, you should consider getting misters.

Misters can cool the ambient temperature by quite a bit, and even as much as 20 to 30 degrees!

Your local home improvement store should sell free-standing misters that can attach to a hose. You can also buy misting system kits that you can mount in your flock's run or hangout area. If you're particularly handy, you can DIY your own misting system.

If you are DIYing, make sure you find fine-spray nozzles that spray. Usually they are rated with something like "0.5 GPH" or "1 GPH" (GPH = gallons per hour). The rating tells you how much water is

sprayed out of the nozzle per hour. You'll want to choose one that sprays a very fine mist and uses as little water as possible. The idea is to mist, not irrigate.

Emergency Measures for Treating Heat Stroke in Chickens

It's critical and imperative that you take immediate measures to save your chicken as soon as you see signs of severe heat stress or heat stroke. Here's what to do in emergency situations!

- **Move:** Bring your patient indoors or to a cool spot and set up an emergency cooling area. Your bathroom, laundry room or mudroom would be ideal.
- **Bathe:** Prepare a cooling bath using a dish tub specifically used for your chickens. Dunk some ice or an ice pack into the water to ensure the water is cool. Let your patient soak in the cool water for at least 5 minutes to bring down his or her core body temperature. The severity of the heat stress will dictate how wet the chicken needs to get in order to adequately cool off. Gently towel dry your patient and place him or her in a quiet comfortable corner with a fan blowing.
- **Electrolytes:** Meanwhile, prepare some electrolytes in some water. You can purchase little electrolyte packets from your feed store and keep it in your emergency kit, or you can make your own. To make your own, all you need is to mix a little bit of raw honey with some water, and a tiny pinch of baking soda or sea salt. If your patient is not drinking by him/herself, you may need to administer the electrolyte water using a feeding syringe or an eyedropper.
- **Overnight TLC:** Prepare an overnight stay with healthy foods. Leave your patient in your home's "henspital" at least overnight for observation, and provide some protein-rich snacks like grubs, and fruit like watermelon, cantaloupe, or berries. The protein will provide energy, and the fruits will be quenching with natural sugars and electrolytes. Be sure he/she is getting enough water. Try sprinkling the grubs into a dish of water so they'll gobble up water while bobbing for their snacks.

Your little feathered patient may appear weak for at least 1 to 3 days. Continue to provide lots of TLC and shade, and maybe even continue to sequester in the henspital until they protest and wants to get out. Protesting is a sign of improvement!

Keep a Cool Flock!

Learning how to recognize, prevent, and treat heat stress in chickens is essential for keeping your flock healthy and cool this summer! Chickens are able to handle cooler temperatures much better than hot weather, so it is a good idea to implement some extra measures during the summer for keeping your chickens cool. Your chickens will appreciate preventative measures such as plenty of shade, healthy and refreshing snacks, and plenty of cool drinking water. When you do recognize severe heat stress or heat stroke in one of your flock members, knowing how to treat it could save your chicken's life! Preparedness and prevention are the key things to keep in mind when helping your flock stay cool this summer!

Five Tips for Free-Ranging Chickens

by Alexa Lehr | 11.01.2021

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Free-ranging is a natural instinct for chickens- they love to forage! Watching a flock of free-roaming chickens can be both entertaining and fulfilling. However, free-ranging does come with certain risks. If free-ranging your beloved flock sounds too risky, but you'd love for them to enjoy the freedom of roaming and naturally foraging, then these tips will help you find a happy medium. With these five tips, you can let your flock enjoy roaming free and keep them safe while they're at it!

#1. Teach your flock to come when called

Teaching your flock to come when they are called is extremely helpful when free-ranging. When you give the signal, your flock will come running to you so that you can easily herd them back into their coop for safety or nightly roosting.

Training your flock to come when called is actually easier than it sounds! All you need is a very motivating treat (think [Grubbles!](#)) and a chosen marker signal. The marker signal should be a noise that is loud enough for your flock to hear no matter where they are free-ranging. Clapping your hands, whistling, shaking a bag, or ringing bells would all make good marker signals.

Start by associating the signal call with the highly motivating treats. While the chickens are in their enclosure or coop, do the marker signal and give them a handful of treats. If you do this every morning and evening for at least a week, your flock will start to associate that noise with yummy treats! Practice calling them out of their coop into the enclosure or from the enclosure back into the coop to further encourage them to come running when they hear the marker signal.

Next will come the big step of letting your flock out to free-range! Let them forage and roam for a little while before testing out the marker signal. They will want to enjoy their freedom for a little while before being called to come back to their coop. When it is time to call them in from free-ranging, make the marker signal and watch them come running! Make sure you make the signal loud enough for them to hear. Repeat the signal several times to further ensure your flock comes running. Give them their treats inside their enclosure or coop and close the door.

Yes, there will be stragglers the first couple of times! The more you make a habit of calling your flock in from free-ranging, the more they'll understand the drill. Having a highly valued reward, like Grubbles, will help immensely by positively enforcing this new behavior.

Training your chickens to come when called while they are out free-ranging makes it easy to quickly pen your flock up when danger is near. It also becomes helpful when you have to put your flock in when you can't supervise them or if the weather turns bad. Plus, it's always fulfilling to see your flock come running whenever you call them- even if they are just coming for the [healthy snacks!](#)

#2. Coop train your flock

Aside from training your flock to come when called, coop training your flock is also helpful if you plan on letting them free-range. Coop training involves teaching your flock to return to their coop at dusk to roost. Chickens like to roost in high, protected areas. Sometimes your flock may think that trees or low bushes make a better roosting spot than their coop. Coop training your flock teaches them that the coop is both a good place to roost and a place that will keep them safe at night.

Coop training starts as soon as you move your [chickens into their coop](#). They can hang out in the enclosure during the day, but they must go into the coop to roost at night. This might involve a nightly routine of tucking all your chickens into their coop every evening. Eventually your chickens will learn to go in on their own and you won't have to encourage them at all! To speed things up, you can even encourage them to go into their coop at dusk by sprinkling a healthy evening snack (like Grubbies) in the coop.

Once your flock is consistently going inside to roost on their own, you can consider them coop trained. When you let them out to free-range, they should instinctually return to their coop at dusk to roost. You may have some rebels or stragglers at first, but a consistent reminder of where to roost at night should teach them to go to the coop and not stay out all night.

Keep in mind that your flock's bedtime may be a little later when they are out free-ranging. Like kids who don't want to leave a play date, your flock will want to get the most out of their free-range time! However, your flock will instinctually resort to their coop for safety before it gets too dark. If your flock is hesitant about returning their coop at night, use the 'come when called' trick to get them into their coop at dusk. Most chickens can't resist a healthy bedtime snack!

#3. Get a rooster

Having a rooster with your flock can prove very helpful when you let them out to free-range. Roosters instinctually have two jobs; to mate with the hens and protect the flock. Having a good rooster with your flock can provide protection and an alarm system while your flock forages and free-ranges.

Specifically, a rooster will provide these benefits to a free-range flock:

- **Alarm call**- they will sound an alarm when danger is near
- **Protection**- some roosters will fight off an attacker to save the rest of the flock
- **Keep the flock together**- a rooster will try and keep all his hens together in one area so he can keep an eye on all of them at once
- **Training**- roosters can make coop training and come-when-called training more effective as they naturally lead the hens to safety and food

Adding a rooster to your free-range flock can provide an extra element of protection and can make free-ranging your flock less stressful!

#4. Designate a free-range area

While it may seem like you are defeating the purpose of free-ranging, you can designate a safe area for your flock to roam and forage in. It allows you to have some control over where they roam and provides a specific area that you can monitor and watch for the safety of your flock.

This will require a little extra work on your part. You will have to fence off a large area for your flock to roam, otherwise it's just like an extended enclosure. Ideally there should be enough space that your flock doesn't completely destroy all the vegetation in the area. You can even set up a rotational system where you rotate your flock through several different free-range areas to allow each area some recovery time in-between rotations. Having three to four pastures that you can rotate your flock through is healthiest for your flock and the environment.

How you fence off the designated area is up to you, but each option has pros and cons. Poultry netting is a cheap option, but not completely predator proof. Chicken wire, hardware cloth, or galvanized fencing are a little more expensive but do provide a little more protection.

When choosing a designated area for your flock to free-range in, consider these elements:

- Plenty of space- so your flock won't completely destroy the area
- Shade- there should be shade and sources of natural cover/protection from arial predators
- Shelter- ideally have a shelter from the elements in the free-range area
- Varied forage- it helps to have a variety of forage types in the designated area, such as pasture and leaf decay
- Water- make sure there is a source of fresh water for your free-ranging flock

Having a designated area for your flock to forage in helps you create a somewhat safer, more protected environment for your flock. It will require some time and investment, but the security of your flock is worth it!

#5. Supervise your free-range

If having a designated free-range area for your flock sounds too limiting, then you could opt to supervise your free-range. Supervised free-range can be as strict or as lax as you like. You can let your chickens out only when you are outside too, or maybe you let your chickens out if you are home.

Having a human presence around can help deter predators. If your flock sees you as [one of their flock members](#), they may also be more apt to hang out around where you are. Being outside or present when your flock is free-ranging allows you to react immediately to any accidents or attacks that may occur during free-range time. Keep in mind that not all predators will be deterred by human presence! Predators can be very bold when they are hungry or just aren't bothered by humans (think stray dogs).

Other household pets or farm animals can also help with supervised free-range time! Dogs that are used to being around chickens can be a huge help in deterring poultry predators. Donkeys, geese, and guinea fowl are also known to be very protective and can help deter predators.

You can also have a certain time of the day that you designate as free-range time. Maybe there are times that you know you are going to be home or working outside, those would be good times to allow your flock some freedom. Keep in mind that early morning and dusk are when predators are going to be the most active. However, that doesn't mean midday attacks should be disregarded either! Predators are not picky as to when they have their chicken dinner!

Free-Range Safely!

A happy, healthy flock will enjoy following their foraging instincts while free-ranging. With a little preparation and precautions, you can help your flock find a healthy balance between safety and their newfound freedom!

Pros and Cons of Keeping Roosters

by Alexa Lehr | 09.17.2021

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Let's face it--roosters have a bit of a public relations problem. Many chicken owners dread the possibility of one of their precious baby chicks growing up to be an aggressive rooster. However, not all roosters are cause for concern. Roosters can be fun, friendly, protective, and a great addition to any backyard flock! If you find yourself contemplating on getting one, knowing the full picture will help you make an informed decision. Here's a breakdown of the pros and cons of rooster ownership, and the results might surprise you!

What Are Roosters Good For? Pros of Keeping Roosters

Why add a handsome roo to your flock? They benefit your flock in many ways overall. In fact, there are plenty of positives when it comes to your flock's overall health and wellbeing.

Flock Protector

One of the greatest benefits that a rooster can provide for the backyard flock is the role of predator protection and alarm system. A rooster instinctually plays two roles in the flock; that of protector and that of breeder (more on the latter in a bit).

Whether the flock stays penned up in their enclosure or are allowed to go out [and free-range](#), a rooster will always be on watch for signs of danger. While the ladies go about their business of laying eggs and foraging, the rooster will engage in those activities too but with a heightened sense of awareness of his surroundings. He will often be the first one to sound the alarm if an aerial predator or ground predator is nearby.

Some roosters may even risk their lives to protect their flock! A rooster may intervene or intercept a predator who is attacking his flock.

Flock Reproduction

The other main role that a rooster plays in the flock is that of breeder. Hens still lay eggs even when a rooster is not present. However, a rooster has to be present in order for the hens to lay fertile eggs that could be incubated. This can be a great benefit if you want to [hatch your own chicks](#) or let a broody hen raise a brood of babies.

A rooster will start fertilizing eggs as soon as he is 6 months old. Factors such as health, diet, and environmental conditions will affect the fertility of a rooster, but if a rooster is well cared for and stays healthy, he can prove a successful father for many years.

Just because your hens are laying fertile eggs doesn't mean you have to stop eating the eggs! Fertile eggs are perfectly safe to eat. A fertile egg only starts to develop after it has been exposed to the right conditions for at least 24 hours. Incubation requires the right temperature and the right amount of humidity.

When you have a rooster with your flock, you have the freedom to collect eggs for incubating or you can even let a broody hen raise her own brood of chicks!

Flock Dynamics

Every flock has its own pecking order. [The pecking order](#) dictates where each member of the flock is at in regard to status. The pecking order helps maintain unity and peace within a flock. Within the pecking order there will be a head hen, the rest of the hens then fall into a dominance order after the head hen with the least dominate birds being at the bottom of the pecking order. As long as everyone respects their individual positions, peace and order is maintained throughout the flock.

A rooster is outside of the hens' pecking order. This allows him to act as flock mediator and peace maker. If the hens get in a squabble together, the rooster will often step in and stop the fight. Hens will usually respect the rooster of their flock. They know his role and enjoy having him around for protection. He can help prevent bullying amongst the hens, settle any fights quickly, and reduce stress within the flock.

Mimic Natural Flocks

Adding a rooster to the flock mimics natural flock dynamics. Before chickens were domesticated, a wild flock of jungle fowl (the ancestors of today's chickens) would consist of one head rooster with a flock of hens. Adding a rooster to your flock of backyard hens mimics this natural flock structure.

Hens will actually enjoy having a polite, friendly rooster in their flock. If the rooster takes his roles seriously and respects his hens' rights, he will be popular amongst the ladies and they will enjoy having him around. Adding a rooster to your flock mimics what nature intended and makes for a natural, sustainable flock!

Help with Flock Training

Having a rooster with your flock can make flock training easier and quicker! Flock training is actually a very helpful skill to master.

You will need to [coop train your flock](#) to go into their coop to roost at night. You may also need to train your flock to come when called if you let them out to free-range. A rooster can help with both of these tasks. Since the hens view the rooster as their flock protector and want to be near him, they will often follow his example when it comes to certain behaviors.

A rooster will also want to keep all his hens together and keep them safe. If you teach the rooster that the coop is a safe place, he will happily round up all his hens and lead them to the coop for nightly roosting. He will also try to keep them all together while they are out free-ranging. When you train your flock to come when called, the rooster may help you round up all the hens and get them into safety or call them in for [healthy snacks](#).

Grubbies

A healthy treat for your flock

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Ease Flock Additions

Roosters can also help make flock integrations easier and smoother. Since roosters naturally want to keep a peaceful flock, they can help the introduction of new flock members go smoother. The gradual introduction and process of integration is still necessary; however, it may not take as long for new chickens to be accepted by the flock when a rooster is present. This is especially true if you are integrating in new pullets or hens. Roosters love to add hens to their flock, so a flock rooster is usually very accepting of new female flock members. He will also keep squabbles between the old flock hens and the new members to a minimum. Having a rooster in your flock makes adding new flock members go a lot smoother and makes integration less stressful on both parties.

Your New Favorite Alarm Clock

We can't discuss roosters without mentioning what a wonderful alarm clock they are! The characteristic crowing of roosters varies depending on breed and individuals, but it is always something to consider when adding any rooster to your flock!

Roosters crow for a variety of reasons including to establish territory, announce his presence, or to communicate frustration, happiness, or warnings. Roosters also don't just crow in the morning. They will crow at any time of the day. So, if you love the sound of crowing, then that could be an added benefit of introducing a rooster to your backyard flock!

Diversity & Personality

Adding a rooster to your flock will add interest, diversity, and personality to your flock. Roosters can be striking individuals and often have exotic and beautiful color patterns.

They come in many shapes and sizes, and each rooster has his own personality. Some are laid back, others are more excitable. Some think they are hot stuff, others like to strut for the ladies, and still others think they are bigger than they really are (think bantam roosters). We will discuss rooster personality later on, but for now, know that some roosters really do love to give hugs, cuddle, and spend time with their chicken keepers.

Don't underestimate the entertainment value of watching a rooster interact with his flock. The different behaviors that a flock protector and flock provider engage in can be fascinating to watch and see first-hand.

Disadvantages of Having a Rooster: Cons of Keeping Roosters

While roosters offer a wide array of benefits, there are some drawbacks some flock owners find when it comes to maintaining peace and harmony in their flocks.

Rough on the Hens

One of the biggest draw backs to keeping a rooster with your flock is the fact that he can be rough on the hens.

The mating process for chickens involves the male mounting the female and standing on her back. To do this, he must grab the hen's head feathers to balance himself on her back. He then moves his legs back and forth in a movement called treading. The treading and head feather grabbing can result in feather loss for the hen. A rooster who engages in mating frequently can cause bare patches of skin on a hen's back and head. This is especially noticeable if the rooster chooses a favorite hen to mate with. The chosen hen will be subject to his loving endeavors more frequently and thus may suffer from feather loss.

Some roosters are more 'gentleman' like and won't be too rough on the hens, however it mostly depends on the rooster's personality. Hen saddles can help prevent feather loss on a hen's back by protecting that area from the rooster's claws and spurs. You can also give the hens a break from the rooster by putting him in rooster jail for a few hours out of each day, or a few days out of the week.

Fighting

Fighting could become a problem if you choose to keep multiple roosters with your flock. While there are ways to successfully manage multiple roosters within your flock, you should always be aware of the possibility of a rooster fight when multiple roosters are kept with a flock of hens.

Roosters will fight for dominance or control of the flock. You can help preventing fighting amongst roosters by ensuring there are plenty of hens for each rooster, plenty of space for each rooster to claim some territory, or free-ranging your flock so that the roosters can easily avoid each other.

Roosters that have been raised together from a young age will also be more likely to co-exist together as adults. Ideally you should have at least 10 hens for each rooster in your flock.

Having a proper hen to rooster ratio in your flock will prevent rooster fights and keep the hens from becoming stressed out by too much rooster attention.

Crowing: Noise Pollution

While crowing may be considered a benefit of keeping a rooster, it can also be considered an annoying feature- especially to your neighbors.

Roosters will not only crow early in the morning, but they also crow all throughout the day. Eventually you will get used to hearing your rooster announce his present throughout the day. However, if a rooster's crowing causes neighborhood unrest, then you may not be able to add a rooster to your flock. If you have neighbors within earshot that might get their feathers ruffled by some extra noise, always check with them before getting a rooster.

Personality Risk

There's always the chance you could get a rooster with a personality that is too protective or aggressive. Keep in mind that aggressive roosters are only acting that way because they perceive you are someone else as a threat to their flock. It is a natural, instinctive behavior, not a feeling of anger towards the person the rooster is being aggressive towards.

However, protective roosters that present a danger to you or your family members may not be able to stay in your flock. When choosing a rooster to keep with your flock, evaluate his personality to see if he will be a good fit for your family and flock. Some breeds are prone to being more protective than

others. In general, breeds that are known to be friendly and docile will also have friendly and docile roosters. Keep in mind there are some exceptions though!

Local Restrictions

Lastly, you should always consider if adding a rooster to your flock is even allowed where you live. If you are keeping chickens within city limits, it's a good idea to check with city ordinances to see if roosters are allowed within city limits. Some towns will allow you to keep hens but won't allow you to keep a rooster. Other times you are only allowed to keep one rooster with a certain number of hens. Always check your city's restrictions if you are thinking of keeping a rooster within city limits.

Roosters: Yay or Nay?

Roosters can be a great addition to any flock! They provide protection, act as flock peacemaker, and provide the opportunity for you to raise your own chicks. Adding a rooster to your flock can add diversity, color, and lots of entertainment to your chicken keeping experience! However, there are some drawbacks to consider when adding a rooster to your flock. Protective behavior, over-mating, excessive crowing, or city ordinances may all be factors that prevent you from adding a rooster to your flock. Weigh the pros and cons of keeping a rooster to decide it's a good fit for you and your hens.

Hens Need Calcium - Here's How to Make Sure They Get Enough

by Alexa Lehr | 05.14.2021

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What are crushed oyster shells doing in the poultry aisle of the feed store? Do you know the significant role that calcium plays in a laying hen's diet? Did you know that [grubs are natural source of calcium for your chickens](#)? If this is all news to you, this article is written for you!

Calcium is an essential nutrient that helps your hens lay well, but it also plays many other roles in keeping your hens healthy. Learning all about calcium, how it functions in the diet, and how to recognize deficiencies and excesses are all important skills to know as a chicken raiser!

Why is Calcium So Important?

An eggshell is made of approximately 90% calcium, which is one of the reasons why calcium is so important in a laying hen's diet. If a hen is laying an egg every other day, she needs a lot of calcium to make a strong, sturdy eggshell every 48 hours. Calcium is also needed throughout the body for various other functions:

- helps control muscle spasms, especially those used while laying an egg
- triggers hormone production for a healthy reproductive system
- essential for breeding hens to lay strong eggs that will hatch into healthy, strong chicks
- helps with blood clotting
- helps maintain a healthy nervous system

- activates enzymes in the digestive system
- ensures proper bone growth and development
- helps the hen's body maintain a proper pH level
- helps control the heart rate of a hen
- is needed for the absorption and utilization of phosphorus

A hen's need for calcium goes far beyond just making strong eggshells. A strong presence of calcium in the diet is essential for the health and longevity of the hen!

The Science Behind it All (for the science nerds!)

Simply knowing that calcium is important for our flock is enough for some of us. However, for the wondering minds out there, knowing how it all works is the fun part! If you are one of those chicken raisers who likes to know the "how" behind every "why", then this section is for you! If not, feel free to scroll for practical tips on incorporating more calcium into your hens diets.

The Formation of Eggshells

Calcium is absorbed from the diet and stored in the medullary cavity of the hen's bones. When calcium is needed for the formation of an eggshell, it is released from the medullary cavity into the bloodstream. This triggers the kidneys to stop excreting extra calcium and instead to start conserving calcium to replace the calcium released into the bloodstream.

Calcium is then drawn from foods in the diet to replace the used up calcium. Then the ovaries release estrogen which signals to the body to start making more medullary bone to store more calcium.

This constant cycle of calcium usage, absorption, conservation, and bone development occurs on a regular basis. The hen needs to consume enough calcium each day to meet the needs of all the systems in her body as well as to use it for creating an eggshell.

Since calcium is drawn from the bones for eggshell development, it is especially important that a laying hen gets enough calcium so that she can both create eggshells and build new bone.

Calcium and the Twin Nutrients

When calcium is consumed by a hen, her body can't use it right away. Two other nutrients need to be present at the same time in order for calcium to be utilized by the hen: phosphorus and vitamin D.

Calcium and phosphorus are both needed in order for each one to be metabolized and used by the body. Phosphorus binds to calcium, which means an imbalance in one leads to an imbalance in the other. Much like calcium, phosphorus helps with bone development as well as plays an important role in the digestion of fats and carbohydrates in the diet. Phosphorus also helps keep the body's pH level balanced, which is essential for warding off disease.

Phosphorus is abundant in the diet since grains are naturally high in phosphorus. However, plant-based phosphorus is not readily available for absorption, thus other sources of phosphorus must be provided (more on that later!).

In order for both calcium and phosphorus to be metabolized, vitamin D must be present. Vitamin D regulates how much calcium is released into the bloodstream for eggshell formation. It regulates the plasma calcium in the blood and determines whether more calcium is released from the medullary cavities of the bones or whether calcium is conserved to replenish the bones.

Vitamin D is a fat soluble vitamin that is stored in the hen's liver after it has been absorbed from the diet. When vitamin D is needed to help metabolize calcium and phosphorus, the kidneys trigger vitamin D secretion.

How to Supplement Calcium

Now that we've got the science out of the way, some important questions remain. If I'm feeding my hens a complete layer feed, do they still need supplemental calcium? What sources of supplemental calcium can I give my hens? Do I need to provide supplemental phosphorus and vitamin D too?

You should provide your laying hens with [supplemental calcium](#) no matter what feed you provide. The need for calcium varies for each hen, but it may be higher or lower depending on these factors:

- Age- older hens need more calcium since their medullary bones have been repeatably depleted for longer
- Diet- a diluted diet (such as with too many unhealthy treats) can lead to a higher need for calcium, likewise, an incomplete diet will also result in an increased need for calcium
- Rate of Lay- hens that are good layers and lay regularly will need more calcium than poor layers
- Season- during high production seasons (like the spring), calcium needs will increase
- Weather- warm weather inhibits calcium absorption and this increases the need for more calcium to be consumed
- Disease- ailments that affect the kidneys and liver will increase the need for calcium since phosphorus and vitamin D absorption are inhibited
- Digestive Health- poor digestive health will increase the need for more calcium

Despite the fact that more calcium is included in layer feeds, supplemental calcium should still be provided in case a hen's calcium need is higher than what is being provided in the feed. Supplemental calcium allows a hen to adjust her calcium consumption based on her needs.

Common Sources of Supplemental Calcium

- [Designed calcium supplements](#)- specially designed, highly bioavailable supplements do a great job of supplying calcium to your flock
- Crushed oyster shells- often sold at feed stores next to the layer feed
- Crushed eggshells- dry eggshells, crush them, and feed them back to your hens (Not Recommended as a replacement for oyster shells - *see below)

- Chipped limestone- less common and cannot be absorbed as readily

You can provide free-choice calcium supplements in a separate feeder or treat dispenser for your hens. They will stop by the free-choice calcium feeder periodically throughout the day and consume little particles of calcium as needed.

The particle size of the calcium supplement must be considered. The pieces need to be small enough that they are easy for the hens to consume. However, they also need to be large enough so that they stay in the digestive track for a longer period of time. Particles that are about pea size or slightly larger are the best for providing adequate calcium. The longer the particle stays in the digestive system being broken down, the more calcium can be absorbed from the supplement.

[Aragonite](#) or crushed oyster shells are the best option for providing supplemental calcium. They stay in the digestive track the longest, which optimizes calcium absorption.

Crushed eggshells make a good supplement in addition to crushed oyster shells. However, they can't be fed by themselves since they don't remain in the digestive track long enough to provide adequate supplemental calcium.

While chipped limestone can work as a supplemental calcium source, it is not highly recommended. It moves through the digestive system too fast and the calcium content can vary depending on the source of the limestone.

What about phosphorus and vitamin D supplements?

Thankfully, most high-quality, complete layer feeds, [such as Grubbly Fresh Pecks Layer Feed](#), contain the appropriate amount of phosphorus and vitamin D needed by laying hens. However, if calcium needs increase, phosphorus and vitamin D needs will increase slightly too. You can provide these healthy snacks during times when supplemental calcium consumption increases:

- [Black soldier fly grubs](#) (excellent balanced source of both calcium and phosphorus)
- Soaked and sprouted sunflower seeds
- Meat and fish (*fish may affect the taste of your eggs)
- Eggs
- Broccoli

It is interesting to note that free-range hens are usually able to control their calcium, phosphorus, and vitamin D need better than confined hens. This is because they can forage for foods that provide the right nutrients that the hens need.

Grubbies

A healthy treat for your flock

With 50x more calcium than mealworms, treat your flock with Grubbies and help support strong eggshells.

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How to Spot Calcium Deficiencies

A calcium deficiency will occur when a hen does not, or cannot, consume enough supplemental calcium to meet her needs. Some of the factors that affect the calcium needs of individual hens will also be causes of a calcium deficiency, such as an improper diet, age, environmental factors, and overall health. A deficiency in phosphorus or vitamin D will also cause a calcium deficiency.

Here are some common signs that would indicate a calcium deficiency:

- Thin or soft shells- eggshells are very weak
- Shell-less eggs- the egg contents are just surrounded by the inner and outer membranes without an actual hard shell
- Abnormal skeletal development- more common in developing chicks
- Rickets- a sign of vitamin D deficiency
- Osteoporosis- this occurs when too much calcium is removed from the bones
- Feather loss
- Egg eating- the hens may be eating their own eggs to replace lost calcium
- Egg-binding- remember, calcium is also needed to control egg laying muscle spasms

A calcium deficiency will eventually lead to a stop in laying. A hen's bones may become fragile, weak, and break easily. A calcium deficiency also weakens a hen's immune system and makes her more susceptible to disease.

How to Diagnose Excess Calcium

While calcium deficiencies are more common than having too much calcium in the diet, excess calcium can occur when a hen consumes too much supplemental calcium and doesn't use the excess. There are two signs that indicate varying degrees of too much calcium consumption:

- Deposits on eggshells- calcium deposits on eggshells appear as bumps on the shell, this just means there was slightly too much calcium released into the bloodstream and is usually nothing to worry about
- Hypercalcemia- causes damage to the heart and other organs, is toxic to the liver, and causes the kidneys to calcify (gout), this occurs when there is truly too much calcium in the diet and the hen's body doesn't know how to handle it all

By providing supplemental calcium that is free-choice, you are allowing the hens to control their calcium needs. A calcium excess may occur if a hen stops laying but doesn't stop consuming supplemental calcium. However, you generally don't have to worry about calcium excesses in the backyard flock.

Guide to Meeting Your Flock's Calcium Needs

To avoid or help resolve a calcium deficiency in your hens' diet, you must know how to manage your flock's calcium needs. While providing free-choice supplemental calcium can help solve and prevent a lot of calcium related issues, knowing how to manage calcium needs under certain circumstances is also important. If you know your flock has a calcium deficiency, you can implement these measures:

- Switch to a better, [high-quality complete layer feed](#).
- Provide supplemental calcium in an easy to access spot. Crushed oyster shells mixed with crushed eggshells are a good option.
- Offer [black soldier fly grubs](#) as a [healthy snack every day](#). These protein-packed grubs also contain a balanced amount of both calcium and phosphorus.

Summer months and warm weather can often present an issue in balancing calcium levels for laying hens. When a hen pants, her body's pH levels increase, which requires more calcium to help rebalance the pH levels. This can present an issue since hens will sometimes eat less during the summer since digestion generates internal heat.

To prevent potential calcium deficiencies, there are a few **summer practices** you can put into play to help your hens get the calcium they need:

- Add electrolytes to your flock's water.
- Continue to offer nutrient dense, calcium-rich snacks, like [Grubblies](#).
- Implement [measures to keep your hens cool](#) to prevent them from panting.
- Encourage your hens to eat most of their food in the morning or evening, when the temperatures are the coolest. Try sprinkling grubs over the feed to encourage feeding time.
- Ensure your hens are getting [a balanced diet](#): a high-quality layer feed (along with only nutrient-dense and hydrating treats, avoid offering too many table-scrap)

What about chicks? How much calcium do they need?

The amount of calcium growing chicks need is less than what a laying hen requires. Instead, chicks actually need more protein. A chick's protein requirements are higher than what a laying hen needs.

Chicks do not need supplemental calcium since they are not drawing on stored calcium every day to create an eggshell. Their main focus is on growth, and [a complete high-quality chick feed](#) will provide them with the proper calcium that they need!

So Much More Than Just Eggshells!

Calcium plays a vital role in the health and productivity of your flock! Not only is it needed for making strong eggshells, but it is also used to support the circulatory system, the nervous system, the cardiac system, and the digestive system of the laying hen. Providing supplemental calcium will allow your hens to manage their own calcium needs and will ensure you are providing all the nutrients your hens need to stay healthy and produce well!

How to Raise Chickens: 7 Essential Components

by Alexa Lehr | 03.12.2021

Last updated: 07.28.2025

With backyard chicken keeping on the rise, there is a lot of information out there about how to raise chickens! Skip all the muck, muddle, and confusion and go straight to the essentials with our 7 core aspects of raising a backyard flock. Raising your own chickens does take time, responsibility, and commitment, but you'll be rewarded with a renewed sense of sustainability and confidence as you care for and maintain your own flock!

#1. Picking the Perfect Breed

The first step on your chicken journey is figuring out what chicken breeds will best suit your needs and situation. Most chicken breeds can be categorized into one of four categories:

- Production breeds developed for egg production
- Meat breeds developed for the purpose of providing a good quantity of meat
- Dual-purpose breeds that can be used for either egg production or for providing meat
- Fancy breeds, mainly for look and appearance, although some are decent egg layers

Decide what your reasons are for raising a backyard flock, then decide which category you should select breeds from based on your needs.

You should also consider if you want to go with heritage chicken breeds or hybrid chicken breeds. Heritage chicken breeds have been genetically preserved over the years and have a breed history. Hybrid chicken breeds have been developed by the production industry for specific purposes. They are typically a combination of breeds and usually cannot be bred true. Meaning, two hybrid chickens cannot be bred together to create the same hybrid breed. Well-bred heritage chicken breeds are typically known for having a longer life span, being hardier, having better temperaments, and being a more sustainable breed option. Hybrid chicken breeds are better at meeting high production expectations. Some strains can have docile, friendly temperaments that are a nice addition to the backyard flock.

Many backyard chicken raisers choose to go with dual-purpose heritage breeds for their first flock. These breeds are often easy to acquire, have friendly temperaments, are hardy, and still produce a good quantity of eggs or meat. Some popular beginner chicken breeds include the Orpington, Australorp, New Hampshire Red, Rhode Island Red, Plymouth Rock, Brahma, and Cochin.

When choosing the perfect breeds for your backyard flock, consider these qualities:

- **Purpose:** Eggs, meat, or both
- **Temperament:** Docile and friendly or flighty and independent
- **Environmental conditions:** Cold hardy breeds, heat tolerant breeds, or both
- **Broodiness:** If you think you might want to have a mama hen raise chicks in the future, consider getting a breed that may have some broody individuals

#2. Raising Chicks

Once you've decided what breeds are best for your first flock, your next task will likely be raising baby chicks! Chicks are cute, fun, and exciting, but they are also a lot of work and responsibility. We'll cover some high level basics on chick raising, but for more details [check out our in-depth guide](#) on how to raise chicks.

First you will need a brooder. A brooder should be a safe and protected home for your new chicks that provides them with food, water, and heat. The brooder should also be lined with an easy-to-clean litter that is absorbent and will prevent any bacteria from building up between cleanings. The food and water should be contained in a chick-size feeder and a chick-size waterer. The feeder should keep the food clean and dry as well as have enough space for all the chicks to eat from the feeder at once. The waterer should keep the water clean and contained and should not present a drowning hazard or any way that a chick could get stuck and become chilled. For a heat source, you can go with a generic heat lamp or a radiant heater. If you go with a heat lamp, you need to have a sturdy system to support the lamp as well as a way to raise or lower the lamp safely. A much safer and more natural option is to invest in a radiant heater. The radiant heater more closely mimics a mother hen, does not present a fire hazard, and allows the chicks to control their heat needs on their own. Learn how to properly set up the brooder for your chicks in [our brooder guide](#)!

The chicks will need supplemental heat in a brooder for at least the first 4-5 weeks of their life. After that, they may need to be moved to a larger pen as they grow. The young chickens can be moved outside after they have grown in all of their juvenile feathers and only if the outside temperatures are reasonable. Ideally, the outdoor temperatures should not be getting below 50-55°F if you permanently move your young chickens to an outdoor coop. Any enclosure or housing that you keep your young birds contained in should be completely predator proof. Sturdy building materials such as wood, hardware cloth, and secure latches are important for keeping your new flock safe from predators.

If you got chickens for the purpose of egg laying, then you can expect the young pullets (female chickens under 1 year old) to start laying around 20-24 weeks of age. The heritage breeds will often take longer to mature to production age than hybrid laying breeds. The first eggs a pullet lays are often small and are sometimes called 'fairy eggs'. Don't worry, the eggs will increase to the normal size for the breed as the pullet's reproduction system gets into the swing of things!

#3. Housing

Those little cute fluff balls will quickly outgrow their brooder, so you'll need safe housing ready for their long term care. If your brooder is large enough, you can keep the young chickens in the brooder until they are old enough (and fully feathered) to move into an outdoor coop. Your flock's coop should be a safe haven for them that provides protection from both predators and the weather. There's countless ways to setup and design an ideal coop, as long as it has all the right elements for your flock. Use this checklist to create your ideal coop:

- **Litter:** Three popular options are [hemp](#), large flake wood shavings, sand, or straw (not hay). Any of these absorbent options should be laid on a solid flooring within the coop.
- **Feeder:** You can choose to do a hanging feeder, a homemade feeder, or a free-standing feeder.

- **Waterer:** Again, you can choose a hanging water system, a nipple water system, or a free-standing waterer.
- **Nesting boxes:** At least one for every 5 hens.
- **Perches:** There are numerous styles of perches, but for any of them, always allow approximately 10 inches of perch space per bird.
- **Predator protection:** Seal off any holes no matter how small they are, secure hardware cloth over window openings or ventilation openings, use predator proof doors and latches.
- **Weather protection:** The coop should be covered with a weather-proof roof and should be sturdy enough to withstand winds and other environmental conditions.

The coop should also be able to accommodate the number of birds you have, as well as allow for "chicken math" to happen in the future. Always build (or buy) for a bigger flock than what you plan on raising! Or at least choose a design that's easy to expand. On average, allow about 2-3 square feet of space per bird in the coop.

The coop should have a weather and predator proof enclosure attached to it, with a chicken door that allows your chickens access from the coop to the enclosure. The enclosure should be secured with predator proof poultry fencing (like hardware cloth) and covered with a weather-proof roof. It should have a litter that is well-draining to prevent puddles from building up in the enclosure. You may also need to install a ramp from the enclosure floor to the chicken door so that the chickens can easily get to their coop. For the enclosure, allow at least 6-8 square feet of space per chicken.

Coops can be as fancy or as frugal as you want (without compromising on the essentials mentioned above). However, there are some nice amenities you may consider adding to your coop design:

- **Electricity:** Helpful for adding light fixtures to the coop or for installing heated water systems.
- **Storage space:** Keep all your cleaning supplies, feed, and extra chicken keeping supplies right out at the coop
- **Automatic Chicken Door:** Never forget to open or close the chicken door for your flock to keep them safe from predators!
- **NiteGuard:** Deter predators by mounting these little warning systems around your coop and enclosure.
- **Curtains and Drapes:** Adds a homey feel to the coop, plus the hens like the privacy of nesting box curtains.
- **Droppings Boards or Slings:** these handy features catch the nightly droppings below the roosts and make for easy poop removal in the morning.

#4. Food & Water

Feeding chickens is pretty simple when you stick to nature's basics. For chicks, you should start them off on a complete chick starter feed, which contains all the nutrients and proper protein for healthy growth and development. The important factor in chick starter feed is the protein level. A

quality chick starter feed should contain between 18-24% protein. A high protein content is essential for proper growth and development. Chick starter feed is also made into smaller particles to make it easier for the chicks to eat and digest.

Grubbly [Little Pecks](#) starter grower chick feed is a great option as it mimics what your chicks would eat in the wild. It's made with [black soldier fly](#) grub protein, plants, vitamins, minerals, and probiotics to ensure your chicks have everything they need to grow up strong and healthy.

Since Little Pecks is both a starter feed and grower feed, you don't have to worry about changing your chick's diet as they grow. If you feed your chicks just a starter feed, then you will want to switch to a grower feed according to the manufacturer's instructions on the feed bag.

Once your young chickens reach about 18-20 weeks of age, you will want to switch them to a layer feed. The layer feed contains all the nutrition they need to support them as they enter reproduction age and start producing eggs on a daily basis. Layer feed is different from chick starter feed in the fact that it is lower in protein and contains more calcium. While laying hens still need a high amount of protein, the percentage can back off to around 16-18% protein since the hens do not need protein for growth and development. The extra calcium in layer feed is essential for helping the hens produce strong, sturdy eggshells. Grubbly [Fresh Pecks](#) is an excellent option since it's a sustainable poultry feed that contains only natural ingredients. Unlike other feeds, you won't find any fishmeal, soy, or corn. All of Grubbly's feeds are made with grubs and plants, so you can keep your chickens on a healthy, natural diet.

With all this talk about hens, you may be wondering about roosters. They don't lay eggs, so should they be fed a layer feed? Roosters do not need the extra calcium that is in layer feed. However, most backyard chicken keepers find it just as easy to feed their whole flock, including roosters, layer feed rather than trying to make sure each sex gets their own feed. Feeding a whole grain layer feed allows the roosters to avoid consuming too much calcium while still being able to consume the ingredients they need for proper nutrition.

Along with the layer feed, you should also supply some essential supplements. There are three main dietary supplements that your flock will need: calcium, protein, and grit.

- **Calcium:** Essential for strong eggshells. Supplemental calcium commonly comes in the form of crushed oyster shells that you provide in a free-choice supplement dispenser for your hens to consume as they wish. The [supplemental calcium](#) can help prevent any calcium deficiencies in your flock's diet which will ensure the hens can stay healthy and productive.
- **Protein:** Supplemental protein is needed during the fall months, when your chickens do their annual fall molt. The molt is when a chicken gradually loses all its feather and regrows them, which [requires lots of protein](#). Supplemental protein may also be needed during the winter months if your region experiences extreme temperatures. Cold weather requires extra protein for helping chickens stay warm and healthy. Supplemental protein can be provided in the form of [Grubblies](#), sunflower seeds, whole oats, meat scraps, or sprouted legumes, to name a few! It can be provided as a daily snack for your flock to help them meet their increased protein needs!
- **Grit:** If your chickens don't have access to dirt or coarse sand, you will need to have a free-choice layer grit supplement available too. Grit is essential for the proper break down of foods in the chicken's crop. There are two kinds of grit, [layer grit](#) and [chick grit](#). Each grit is formulated for the appropriate age. Layer grit will contain larger particles and be coarser than

chick grit. If your flock free-ranges or you use sand as the coop litter, supplemental grit will not be needed.

Your flock should have access to fresh, clean drinking water at all times. Clean and refresh the water at least once a day to prevent algae or bacteria from building up in the waterer. Any feeder or waterer system you use should keep the contents clean and free from debris. The feeder should also keep the food dry since wet feed can easily mold and cause disease. Both the feeder and the waterer should hold the appropriate amount of food for the size flock that you raise. Ideally, both should contain enough food/water to last your flock two days. The feeder should be located in a place where rodents and wild birds cannot access it. Your flock should have free-choice access to food and water all day long. Chickens naturally snack on their food throughout the day, which provides their metabolism with energy to keep them active all day long.

#5. Daily Care & Cleaning

Your flock will require daily care, ideally at least twice a day. Of course, since chickens are so fun and entertaining to watch, you will find yourself spending more time out at the coop than you ever imagined! But aside from entertainment, there is also work to be done. Here are some chores that should be done a daily basis:

- Clean up droppings
- Fill the feeder
- Clean and refresh the water
- Collect eggs
- Open and close the chicken door in the morning and evening

When and how you decide to get these chores done is up to you and your schedule! There will also be chores that don't need to be done on a daily basis but they still need weekly or monthly attention. Some weekly chores may include cleaning up droppings in the enclosure or getting more [chicken feed](#) or supplements. Monthly chores may include cleaning out the coop litter and refreshing the nesting box litter. If you use large flake wood shavings as the litter in the coop, they will need to be cleaned out about every 3-4 months. A chore that should be done at least once a year is a thorough cleaning of the chicken coop. Chickens naturally make a mess and create 'chicken dust'. A yearly cleaning of the coop will help prevent disease causing organisms from taking up permanent residence as well as control factors that can cause respiratory or lung issues.

If you live in regionally cold or regionally warm climates, then you may have some additional chores to do depending on the season. For areas that experience severe winters, [winterizing the chicken coop](#) is a must! For regions that experience hot summers, you'll need to take [measures to prevent heat stress](#).

#6. Troubleshooting

While we all wish to raise a happy and healthy flock, it's likely that one or more of your chickens will experience health issues. Since your flock will spend most of their time outdoors, there are numerous environmental factors that can take a toll on the health of your flock. Not to mention factors such as genetics, flock dynamics, and stress. While the list of poultry ailments could fill a book, we will just touch on a few basics for monitoring and controlling the health of your flock.

First, you must know the signs and symptoms of a sick chicken. Chickens are prey animals, so they instinctually hide their weaknesses as best they can for as long as they can. Learning to recognize even the most basic signs of disease can be a huge help in monitoring the health of each flock member. Here are some basic signs that a sick chicken will exhibit:

- Lethargy- huddled with ruffled feather, not participating in normal behaviors and activities
- Diarrhea- especially poops that are runny, whiteish, contain blood, are mostly bile or contain worms
- Shriveled comb and wattles- can also be pale in color or discolored
- Coughing, sneezing, wheezing, or rattling
- Discharge from the eyes, nostrils, or mouth
- Thinness- feel along the breastbone for adequate meat/muscle
- Poop stuck to the vent feathers- often accompanied by diarrhea
- Stop in egg production

Unfortunately, many chicken diseases and ailments have overlapping signs and symptoms. This can make it very hard to make an accurate diagnosis. However, there are some fairly basic ailments that you should be aware of as you venture into raising a healthy flock:

- **Bumblefoot:** Appears as a black dot on the foot pad, may be accompanied by limping
- **Crop issues:** Sour smelling breath indicates [sour crop](#), an enlarged and hard crop in the morning could mean [impacted crop](#)
- **Respiratory Issues:** Characterized by coughing, sneezing, wheezing, and sometimes discharge
- **Internal parasites:** Can cause diarrhea and weight loss, you may even see worms in the droppings
- **External parasites:** Look for tiny bugs crawling around the vent as well as parasite egg deposits at the base of the feathers

It is a good idea to do a monthly health check to stay on top of your flock's health. Once a month, handle every member of the flock and examine them for signs of ailments and external parasites.

Your daily chores are an integral part of your flock's health. Proper coop cleaning, a proper diet, and access to clean drinking water will set your flock up for success. When sickness or disease does strike, quarantine the ailing bird while you try and identify the issue. If you can determine an appropriate treatment, care for the bird until it returns to good health and can be re-integrated back into the flock.

#7. Treats, Supplements, & Snacks

When you're done playing Chicken Doctor, treating your flock to healthy snacks can be a great way to promote health and bond with your birds. As with humans, too much of a good thing can make them sick, so always treat in moderation.

So what would a chicken consider a "treat"? Chickens are omnivores and can eat a wide range of foods, including items that may not be as palatable to us. Feeding your flock your leftover table scraps is one sustainable way to spoil them. Healthy table scraps that you can give your flock on a regular basis include fruit and vegetable scraps and cooked meat scraps. Table scraps that should be limited or fed in moderation include whole grain bread and whole grain cereals or pastas.

Along with table scraps, you can also feed your flock nutritious snacks. These are foods that supplement your flock's diet but are not essential to their daily well-being. [Grubblies](#) are one of the healthiest snacks you can feed your flock. These dried black soldier fly grubs mimic what chickens would naturally forage for in the wild. While many chicken owners feed their chickens mealworms as a supplement, [black soldier fly grubs](#) have 50x more calcium to support egg production. They're also packed with protein to help your birds grow healthy and strong feathers. Once your chickens are familiar with Grubblies, you'll find all you have to do is shake the bag- they'll come running! It's a great trick to round them up quickly back into their coop after free ranging. Other nutritious snacks that can be fed (in moderation) include whole grains such as oats, seeds (like sunflower seeds), and legumes (like lentils or peas).

Lastly, you can also venture into the wonderful world of natural supplements for chickens. Natural supplements are used to prevent certain ailments and disease, boost the immune system, or address certain issues within the flock. Natural supplements should be used with a knowledge of what the specific supplements do and how they can be provided to your flock. Some common natural supplements include apple cider vinegar, garlic, various herbs and spices, probiotics, sea kelp, and brewer's yeast. Some good beginner supplements to start off with include adding crushed garlic to your flock's water once a week and supplying them free-choice herbs that they can consume as they wish.

Best Chicken Breeds for Beginners

by Alexa Lehr | 10.06.2021

Last updated: 01.03.2025

With a wide range of chicken breeds available to the backyard chicken keeper, choosing just a few breeds to include in your first flock can seem daunting. Each chicken breed has its quirks and personality traits so it's important to choose breeds that will best fit your lifestyle. The following six chicken breeds are perfect a beginner's first flock and are favorites amongst long-time chicken raisers as well!

#1. Orpington

Origin: United States

Weight: cock- 10 lbs., hen- 8 lbs.

Breed Class: English

Varieties: black, blue, buff, white

Appearance: If nothing else, the Orpingtons' large, fluffy appearance will be enough to make you want to get some! Orpingtons are richly feathered with loose, fluffy plumage. Their feathers are broad, smooth, and thickly cover their large, robust bodies. This gives them a very plump, fluffy appearance.

Orpingtons have a single, upright comb. The comb, earlobes, and wattles are all a bright red color. Orpingtons can be both standard size (7.5-10lbs) or bantam size (3-3.5lbs).

Breed Traits: Orpingtons are considered a dual-purpose chicken breed, which means they can be raised for both egg production and for meat. As meat birds, Orpingtons are valued for their large size and fast growth rate. However, most chicken raisers value Orpingtons for their good egg production and friendly disposition. The hens are good layers, even during the winter months, and will produce about 200-250 eggs a year. Orpington eggs are large and brown in color.

Orpingtons are a very cold hardy breed, however, the cock's large comb and wattles can be prone to frostbite. Orpington hens will go broody and make great mothers! Standard size Orpingtons are a large breed and will [need more coop space](#) and lower perches.

Temperament: Orpingtons are best known for their friendly, calm, and affectionate personalities. These birds truly are the Golden Retrievers of the chicken world! Orpingtons are very docile and when handled from a young age, will even get attached to their chicken raisers. These birds are the perfect choice for families with young children or for youth who want to show off their chickens in a county fair!

Best Beginner Qualities:

- Extremely docile and friendly
- Good egg layers of large size eggs
- Cold hardy
- Get along well with other chicken breeds
- Adapt to both confinement and free-range

#2. Australorp

Origin: Australia

Weight: cock- 8.5 lbs., hen- 6.5 lbs.

Breed Class: English

Varieties: black

Appearance: Australorps have rich, black plumage that often has a green or blue sheen in the sunlight. Their bright red comb, wattles, and earlobes contrast stunningly with their black feathers. Australorps are loosely feathered, however, their feathers lay flat and close to their body giving them a sleek but fluffy appearance.

Australorps have a single, upright comb with five evenly serrated points with hens having a smaller comb than the roosters. Both sexes have smooth earlobes, well-rounded wattles, and a black beak. Australorps can be either standard size (5-7lb) or bantam size (1.7-2.2lb).

Breed Traits: Australorps are also considered a dual-purpose breed and can be used for both meat or egg production. Their pinkish white skin and large, meaty carcasses make them good for meat production. The hens are excellent layers, producing over 200 eggs a year. The eggs are light brown and large in size. Australorps are fast maturing and the hens will go broody.

Australorps are a very cold hardy breed, however, the cock's large comb and wattles can be prone to frostbite.

Temperament: Australorps are another extremely docile breed that make great backyard pets and are perfect for youth chicken raisers. They are friendly and calm, with unique and curious personalities. The hens are known to be on the quieter side and will bond with their chicken keepers.

Best Beginner Qualities:

- Docile and calm
- Excellent egg layers of large, brown eggs
- Cold hardy
- Get along well with other chicken breeds
- Adapt well to both confinement or free-range

#3. Plymouth Rock

Origin: United States

Weight: cock- 9.5 lbs., hen- 7.5 lbs.

Breed Class: American

Varieties: barred, black, blue, buff, Columbian, partridge, silver penciled, white

Appearance: Plymouth rocks are a tight but richly feathered breed that come in many different varieties (colors). The most common variety is the barred Plymouth Rock, which features a stunning bluish/black and white feather pattern. Characteristic of the breeds in the American class, Plymouth Rocks have yellow skin, beak, shanks, and toes.

Plymouth Rocks have a single, upright comb with five points that are evenly serrated. Both sexes have elongated earlobes and well-rounded wattles. All facial features are bright red in color. Plymouth Rocks can be either standard size (6.5-7.5lb) or bantam size (2.5-3.5lb).

Breed Traits: Plymouth Rocks are a great dual-purpose breed that can be used for both meat production or egg production. At one point, Plymouth Rocks were the most common chicken breed in America because of how versatile they were. The hens can lay an amazing amount of 260-300 eggs a

year! The eggs are light brown and medium to large in size. Plymouth rock hens will go broody and make great mothers. Plymouth rocks are very cold hardy yet can handle [hot temperatures](#) as well.

Temperament: Plymouth Rocks are a little bit more of an active breed, but they are still known to be docile and friendly when handled from a young age. They have strong personalities but can be calm and affectionate towards their chicken raisers. Any chicken can be encouraged to be friendly and docile, especially when [Grubbies](#) snacks are involved!

Best Beginner Qualities:

- Docile and friendly
- Superb egg layers
- Good dual-purpose breed
- Cold hardy and moderately heat tolerant
- Adapt well to both confinement or free-range

#4. Wyandotte

Origin: United States

Weight: cock- 8.5 lbs., hen- 6.5 lbs.

Breed Class: American

Varieties: barred, birchen, black, black-breasted red, blue, blue red, brown red, buff, buff Columbian, Columbian, golden laced, lemon blue, partridge, silver laced, silver penciled, splash, white, white-laced red

Appearance: Wyandottes are heavily feathered with loose, fluffy plumage. They have a well-rounded body that gives them a fluffy, robust appearance. Their legs are fairly stout and set apart. Wyandottes have a somewhat round look to them since their tails are held at a 40° angle and heavily feathered, thus smoothing out angular curves their body might have.

Wyandottes have a rose comb that sits tightly to their head. Both sexes have oblong earlobes and well-rounded wattles. All facial features are a bright red in color and the beak is always a shade of yellow. Wyandottes can be either standard size (5.5-6.5lb) or bantam size (1.5-2lb).

Breed Traits: Wyandottes are another great dual-purpose breed that can be used for both meat production or egg production. They are fast maturing, have meaty carcasses, and have a short back which appeals to modern day consumers. The hens lay an average of 200 eggs a year. Their eggs are brown in color and medium in size. Wyandotte hens will occasionally go broody and make good mothers when they do brood.

Wyandottes are a very cold hardy breed because of their lustrous feathering and short rose comb.

Temperament: Wyandottes can have a variety of temperaments, but are considered a docile, friendly breed of chicken. When handled from a young age, Wyandottes can grow into curious and calm

adults that don't mind being picked up and handled. Their exotic coloring and calm disposition make them a popular choice for youth shows.

Best Beginner Qualities:

- Calm
- Good egg layer
- Good dual-purpose breed
- Very cold hardy
- Get along well with other chicken breeds
- Adapt well to both confinement or free-range

#5. Rhode Island Red

Origin: United States

Weight: cock- 8.5 lbs., hen- 6.5 lbs.

Breed Class: American

Varieties: single comb, rose comb

Appearance: Rhode Island Reds have a beautiful, rich dark brown plumage color with the feathers in their tail being nearly black in color. They are more smoothly feathered which gives them a sleek but soft appearance.

Rhode Island Reds can have two different types of combs, a single comb or a rose comb. The single combed variety has a straight single comb with five even points. The rose comb variety has a medium size rose comb that sits tightly to the head. The single comb variety is the most common. Both sexes have medium sized earlobes and wattles. All facial features are a bright red in color with the beak being a reddish horn color. Rhode Island Reds can be either standard size (6.5lb) or bantam size (1.8lb).

Breed Traits: Rhode Island Reds were developed to be an excellent dual-purpose breed. They are considered a utility breed that can be raised for meat production or for their superior egg laying qualities. They are fast maturing and excellent layers with a meaty frame. The hens lay around 290-310 brown eggs a year that are medium to large in size. Rhode Island Reds are excellent foragers and do well with free-ranging. These hens rarely go broody.

Rhode Island Reds are cold hardy and can handle hot temperatures.

Temperament: Rhode Island Reds are a more active breed but are intelligent and can be raised into friendly, calm adults. Most Rhode Island Reds have a docile disposition and are very curious. They are often at the top of the pecking order and may seem a little assertive with less dominant breeds when in a mixed flock. The roosters can have a more assertive temperament.

Best Beginner Qualities:

- Calm
- Superb egg layers
- Good dual-purpose breed
- Cold hardy and moderately heat tolerant
- Adapt well to both confinement or free-range

#6. Sussex

Origin: England

Weight: cock- 9 lbs., hen- 7 lbs.

Breed Class: English

Varieties: birchen, buff, dark brown, light, red, speckled, white

Appearance: Sussex are finely curved birds with smooth feathering. They are soft, robust, and elegant in appearance with their smoothly curved back that leads into a 45° angled tail and a plump round breast.

Sussex have a single, upright comb with five well defined points. Both sexes have medium sized earlobes and small, well-rounded wattles. All facial features are a bright red in color. Sussex chickens can be either standard size (7lb) or bantam size (2.5lb).

Breed Traits: Sussex are a great dual-purpose breed. They have a plump, meaty body but are also excellent producers of medium-sized, light brown eggs. The hens lay around 250-270 eggs a year. Sussex hens will go broody occasionally and make good mothers. Their calm disposition makes them get along well with a variety of other chicken breeds. Sussex are very cold hardy yet can handle hot temperatures as well.

Temperament: Sussex are similar to Orpingtons when it comes to temperament and disposition. They are calm, docile, friendly, and have a reputation of being extremely curious. While they can be a little more active than the Orpingtons, Sussex can form bonds with their chicken raisers and are a great breed for youth to raise. They are smart, curious, and bold when it comes to trying new things!

Best Beginner Qualities:

- Friendly and curious
- Good egg layers
- Cold hardy and moderately heat tolerant
- Get along well with other chicken breeds
- Adapt well to both confinement or free-range

The Perfect Fit

While many of these chicken breeds have quite a few things in common, they all have their own quirks and benefits. When choosing chicken breeds to create your first flock with, you will more than likely be attracted to friendly chicken breeds that are good egg layers. You also want a flock that will thrive in your area, meet your chicken raising expectations, and be perfect for a backyard situation. All six of these breeds fit the bill and would be a great choice for first time chicken raisers and old pros alike! They are a joy to raise and care for, and you are sure to form a special bond with whatever birds you choose.

Building the Perfect Chicken Coop

by Alexa Lehr | 10.08.2021

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What Should be Inside a Chicken Coop

Before you even bring home your [baby chicks](#), you should have a plan in place for building their future home. Once your chicks are old enough, they will [move out of the brooder](#) and into a chicken coop. The chicken coop should provide your flock with everything they require to meet their daily and instinctual needs. This includes shelter, protection, food, water, a place to roost, a place to lay eggs, and a safe place to stretch their legs and interact no matter the weather! Raising a happy, healthy flock starts by having a safe and functional chicken coop ready for them to live in!

Just the Guidelines

With the world of design and architectural plans just a few clicks away, the volume of chicken coop designs has skyrocketed right along with the growing interest of raising backyard chickens. For as many flock owners as there are, there are just as many unique chicken coops! Chicken coops can be as [fancy](#) or as simple as you'd like. However, there are several key guidelines you must follow to make the chicken coop functional. This post is not intended to advise on any specific building plans or tell you how to build your coop. Our goal is to teach you what to look for as you shop for a coop, or ensure you have the guidelines to create and design your own amazing coop.

How to Set Up a Chicken Coop: The Groundwork

The placement of the chicken coop will affect the health and safety of your flock. Ideally, the chicken coop should be located in a shaded spot that is on high, level ground. You generally want to go with a more shaded location if you have the option. Chickens can handle cooler temperatures a lot easier than warmer temperatures. Placing the coop where it can stay shaded and cool during the summer is important for [preventing heat related ailments](#) with your flock. Shaded locations are often protected locations, which is helpful during the winter. Having a natural weather and wind-block near the coop will prevent any environmental stress if you live in a location that experiences varying weather conditions.

Along with location, you also need to consider the size of the chicken coop. Consider these important factors:

- How many chickens you are starting off with?
- How many chickens you plan to get in the future?
- Allow for chicken math (because it's real!)
- Consider including storage space

On average, allow for 2-3 square feet of coop space per standard size chicken. Even if you are starting off with a small flock, always plan out a larger coop than you will need! For bantam chicken breeds (basically miniature chickens), allow for 1-2 square feet per bantam. You will want to take into consideration the amount of space that feeders, waterers, nesting boxes, and roosts will take up within the coop as well.

Having additional storage space in the chicken coop is not essential, however, it is helpful for storing feed and for keeping cleaning supplies handy and near the flock. Storage space within the coop will need to be kept clean and tidy to prevent any pests or predators from taking up residence in the storage space with a free buffet nearby (aka, your flock 🐔). Aside from storing supplies, having extra space attached to the chicken area of the coop is helpful for preventing chickens from escaping, collecting eggs without entering the chicken area, and for cleaning the coop.

The materials that the chicken coop is made from should be strong and sturdy. Wood is an ideal building material since it can be built into a strong, sturdy, and long-lasting structure. The chicken coop building material should also be weather resistant and predator proof. Rain, wind, snow, hail, or sleet, nothing should affect the durability of your chicken coop! The coop materials should not be able to be chewed through, torn apart, or dug under. Predators can be determined creatures, and the coop must keep your flock safe!

If you're designing your own coop, a few basic layout tips can help vastly optimize your overall setup. If you're shopping for a coop, you can use these criteria to judge the best option:

- Usually, the chicken door should be located on the south facing side of the chicken coop.
- If designing a large coop, include a full-size door to make it easier for you to access the coop and clean the coop.
- Windows should be located on the east and west facing sides of the chicken coop.
- Avoid having the windows placed above or across from the roosts to prevent any drafts or winds from bothering the chickens while they sleep.
- Block off or avoid having any unintentional ledges, shelves, or rafters within the chicken area that the chickens may be tempted to roost (and poop) on.
- Avoid having dark corners in the coop.
- Design the coop with ease of cleaning in mind!

Roofing & Flooring

The chicken coop roof and floor should be built out of strong, sturdy materials, much like the overall chicken coop. Both the roof and the floor should be weather-proof and predator-proof. The roof should keep rain and other precipitation out of the chicken coop and it should also shed water to prevent any build-up of precipitation on the top of the coop. The floor of the chicken coop should be made from solid material. Having a solid floor versus a wire floor in the coop allows you to use a litter in the coop. Litter helps make coop cleaning easier, is more predator proof, and is healthiest for the chickens. The coop roof and floor should not allow any access points for predators to sneak through or under and enter the chicken coop.

Ventilation & Light

Adequate ventilation and light in the chicken coop are essential to the health of your flock. Ventilation allows for the old, stale air contained within the coop to be exchanged with fresh, oxygen laden air from the outdoors. Proper ventilation also keeps ammonia fumes from building up within the coop, a problem that can also be prevented by adequate coop cleaning.

You want the chicken coop to be well ventilated but without drafts. The difference between ventilation and drafts is a matter of air flow. Ventilation allows for air exchange whereas drafts are a one-way air current that often blow cold air into the coop.

Ways to maintain ventilation in your coop include:

- Install windows that can be opened or closed depending on the weather.
- Build air vents near the roof of the coop that allow for air exchange.
- Design your coop to include a cupola that allows for coop ventilation.
- Any open ventilation holes should be covered with ¼" hardware cloth to keep out predators.

Having a well-lit chicken coop is also essential for both the health of your flock and to make cleaning and coop maintenance easier for you. You can use natural light, artificial light, or a combination of both. To achieve a well-lit coop with natural light, you should have plenty of large windows. If you live in a region that has cold winters, you will want to consider how you can partially insulate the large windows during the winter while still allowing in natural light. Artificial lighting is also an option if you install electricity out at the chicken coop or rig up a solar light system. LED rope lights are a great option as they are safe to use in the coop and provide a soft light that puts less strain on the hens.

Again, design plays a key factor in the success of your coop. A well-ventilated coop and well-lit coop can be achieved through a few thoughtful design considerations, such as windows. There are a few tips you should consider when installing windows in the chicken coop:

- Have windows on the east and west sides of the coop to maximize the amount of natural light that shines into the coop.
- Consider having windows that can be opened or closed depending on the temperature and weather.
- If the windows can't be opened and closed, then have a method of insulating the windows for when [you have to winterize the coop](#).

- Make sure the windows are predator-proof. Cover the inside of the windows with ¼" hardwire cloth to keep most predators out.



Nesting Boxes

For the laying flock, nesting boxes are an essential element in coop design! Hens like to lay their eggs in locations that appear safe, slightly dark, and have [clean litter](#). This is exactly what the nesting boxes should achieve in your chicken coop. You should provide one nesting box for every 4-5 laying hens in your flock. Hens like to have choices when they are looking for a spot to lay their eggs. Even then, you will often find that all your hens will prefer to lay in the same box. This is a result of their nesting instinct, as it is natural for a hen to build up a clutch of eggs, even if they aren't all her own, to sit on and incubate. Don't worry- only broody hens will go through the process of incubating and hatching a clutch of eggs.

The nesting boxes should be the proper size for your hens while also being able to accommodate the largest hen in your flock. Here are some size standards to keep in mind:

- Large breed nesting box size- 14" wide x 14" high x 12" deep
- Medium breed nesting box size- 12" wide x 14" high x 12" deep

Place your nesting boxes within the chicken coop. If you design the boxes so that they can be accessed from outside of the coop, make sure the latch on the boxes is secure so that no predators can sneak in through the nesting boxes. However, it's easier to have the nesting boxes installed completely within the coop.

Line your nesting boxes with clean litter and have a rail running along the outside. The rail makes it easier for the hens to access the nesting boxes. It should be no further than 5" away from the nesting boxes to discourage the hens from using the rail as a roost. Ensure your nesting boxes are lower than the roosting bars in the coop. Chickens instinctually look for the highest place to roost (sleep) for the night. If they start roosting in the nesting boxes, it can lead to a host of unintended consequences. To

discourage your hens from wanting to sleep in the nesting boxes, make sure they are lower than the roosting bars.

Roosts

Roosts are what chickens sleep on at night. Chickens instinctively look for someplace safe and high off the ground to perch for the night. The roosts in the chicken coop should be a safe place that appeals to your flock's instinctual roosting habits.

Chicken Roost Designs

There are two common types of roosts to use in the chicken coop:

- ladder roosts- these roosts are staggered vertically, much like a ladder leaning up against a wall
- horizontal roosts- these are roosting bars that generally run across one side of the coop and are parallel to the coop wall

Ladder roosts give your flock the option of perching high or low, depending on the breed and weight of the bird. Horizontal roosts often make droppings management easier. If you have heavier breeds in your flock, you will want to make sure the roosts are not higher than 2-3 feet off the ground. Heavier breeds can have feet and leg issues if they are routinely jumping up and down from high roosts. For lighter, more agile breeds the roosts can be slightly higher off the ground since these breeds will want roost in higher places. Allow for 8-12 inches of roost space per chicken, and of course, allow for flock additions and chicken math to occur!

Roosts can be made from a variety of materials, as long as they are safe and provide good grip for the chickens. Two by four boards that have been sanded make for great roosting boards. Rough but sturdy tree branches will also work as roosting bars. Do not use dowels or other slippery, round materials. You want the roosts to have enough purchase for the chickens to get a good grip and not slip off, but you also want the roosts to be splinter free. Don't use materials that could potentially cut or splinter off into a chicken's foot. Roughly sanding down the roosts ever so often is a good idea for keeping the roosts safe and clean.

Droppings Management System

Having a droppings management system in the chicken coop is not essential, but it sure helps with cleaning the coop! Chickens poop at night while they roost. That means every morning there will be a collection of droppings that needs to be removed so that no ammonia fumes build up within the coop. Installing a droppings management system below the roosts can make morning clean up go a lot faster and it can also prevent your flock from having to walk through the droppings every morning. A couple of popular droppings management systems include:

- Droppings boards- These boards are mounted about 4-5" below the roosts and extend about 6-7" beyond the roosts on either side. They catch the nightly droppings so that in the morning the poop just has to be scrapped off the board and into a bucket to be deposited in a compost pile.
- Poop slings- Slings are made from sturdy fabric and are slung below the roosts. The slings collect the nightly droppings and then are cleaned off in the morning.
- Poop trays- Poop trays are trays that are positioned below the roosts and lined with litter to make removing the nightly droppings easier in the morning. The trays just need to be

dumped out and re-installed for the next night. It helps to have a hardware or chicken wire covering fashioned over poop trays to keep the chickens from walking through the trays in the morning.

Droppings boards work well for horizontal roosting systems whereas poop slings and poop trays work well with ladder roosting systems.

Feeders and Waterers

Your flock's feeder and waterer can either be kept inside the coop or outside in the enclosure that is attached to the chicken coop. If the feed and water is kept inside the coop, account for this space in your coop design. You must also be very careful about cleaning up spills. Spilled feed will attract rodents and predators. Spilled water will dampen the litter and provide a place for bacteria to grow.

If you keep the feed and water outside, you will want to at least bring the feeder in to a safe location every night. Predators will be attracted to [chicken feed](#), which is something you want to avoid. Depending on how many chickens you are raising, you may need more than one feeder or waterer. Consider the location and how much space the feeder and water system will require in the coop.

How much space the feeder and water require may depend on the type of system you choose to use. Hanging systems are often the best choice for getting the most out of your coop space since they simply hang from the coop ceiling and don't require additional floor space. However, free-standing systems can also be used, or you can create systems that mount right to the coop wall. Feeders and water systems should always be at back height to your shortest chicken. This height limits feed waste and helps keep both the feed and water clean. Whatever feeding and water system you choose to use, just make sure it is easy for the chickens to access, can't be tipped over or jostled, and that it keeps the contents clean and free of debris.

Some popular chicken feeder and water systems include:

- Poultry water nipples- can be fashioned into a hanging system or a wall-mount system
- Bell feeders and waterers- can be hung or created into a free-standing system
- Homemade PVC feeder and waterers- can be made into hanging systems or free-standing systems

Doors

The doors of the chicken coop are pretty self-explanatory, but you should be aware that a chicken coop needs at least two doors: one for the chickens to use and one for you to use! The chicken door should lead from the chicken coop to the enclosure that is attached to the chicken coop. It should be large enough to accommodate your largest hen, but it does not need to be a full-size door. The chicken door may also need a ramp that leads down from the coop to the ground in the enclosure. The door that you use should be a full-size door so that you can come and go with ease as you clean and maintain the coop.

Any doors installed at the chicken coop should be predator proof and able to be latched securely. Screen doors can be used as long as they are installed with a storm door that must be closed every night to keep predators out. Latches used to close doors should be easy to use but too tricky for predators to figure out how to open.

The chicken door will need to be opened every morning and closed every evening after your flock has gone in to roost for the night. For even greater luxury, you may consider investing in an automatic chicken door. These can be programmed to open and close at certain times or at dawn and dusk. Quality automatic chicken doors are easy to install, are safe for the chickens, and are predator proof.

Electricity

Another nonessential but helpful feature out at the coop is electricity. Having electricity installed out at the coop can be helpful for various reasons:

- If you live in cold regions, electricity allows you to use electric water heaters to keep water from freezing during the winter.
- Electricity gives you the option of supplying supplemental light during short winter days to encourage your hens to keep laying.
- It can also be very helpful for cleaning the coop and running electric appliances like a shop-vac or power washer.

Electricity that is installed out at the coop should be safe and hazard free. Keep electrical outlets out of the chicken area and any cords should be securely fastened down. The electricity should be properly installed, and all electrical safety measures should be followed. No open wires or outlets should be present in the chicken coop. Always follow any code requirements based on your location.

Enclosure

The final item to consider when building or designing a chicken coop is the enclosure. An ideal enclosure is attached to the chicken coop by a door, allowing your flock easy access to both spaces. A full-size door should also be installed in the enclosure so that you can easily enter and exit.

It's important that any enclosure is both weather-proof and predator proof. This allows your flock to get safe exercise no matter the weather. It also helps prevent boredom and allows the chickens to participate in normal bird activities on a daily basis. You will find that your flock will spend a majority of their day outside in their enclosure, which helps keep the chicken coop cleaner.

The chicken coop enclosure should allow about 8-10 square feet of space per chicken. A spacious enclosure will pay off in the long run with preventing behavior issues, boosting flock health, and keeping the coop clean. The enclosure should be completely encased in a predator proof material. Some are better than others, but here is a few popular options:

- Chicken wire- Not entirely predator proof, but the cheapest option.
- Hardwire cloth (1/4")- The most predator proof choice.
- Galvanized livestock fencing- Galvanized fencing is very predator proof but can allow access for smaller predators like weasels, snakes, and opossums.
- Poultry netting- Poultry netting is the least predator proof.

The chicken coop enclosure should be covered and have a well-draining litter on the ground. A covered enclosure allows for year-round daily use and protects against arial predators. A well-draining litter keeps the enclosure from getting too muddy or wet, which is essential for maintaining flock

health. Having loose soil in the enclosure stimulates natural flock behaviors like dust bathing and foraging.

The enclosure can also be a great place to include entertainment features. Homemade perches, ramps, balance beams, swings, and other chicken toys can all be installed in the chicken coop enclosure to stimulate activity and prevent boredom.

The feeder and water can also be kept in the chicken coop enclosure during the day. Just make sure you bring the feeder inside every evening to avoid attracting predators.

Fun & Functional!

Make your chicken coop as fancy as you want it, just make sure the coop includes all the essential elements like roosts, nesting boxes, a feeding system, and a water system. By following these guidelines, you can be sure that your chicken coop is both functional and fun for you and your flock. A safe, secure chicken coop combined with a spacious, predator proof enclosure will make for a happy and healthy flock of chickens!